

INTRODUCTION

How did different cultures around the world come up with ways to organize days into months and years? The most common approaches were a lunar calendar, based on the approximately 30-day cycle of the Moon, and a solar calendar that uses one cycle of Earth's rotation around the Sun – a little bit more than 365 days.

A global calendar

The vast majority of countries around the world now use the same solar calendar in everyday life. This calendar is called the Gregorian calendar. However, many religious and traditional festivals are worked out using a lunar calendar, which is why celebrations such

Julius Caesar added a month named after himself to the Julian calendar, the month we know today as July.

as Diwali, Easter, Ramadan, and Rosh Hashanah do not fall on the same days each year.

The calendar we use today had its origins in ancient Rome. In 46 BCE, Julius Caesar ordered the creation of a more accurate calendar that reflected the solar year. This new calendar, which

came into effect on 1st January 45 BCE, was made up of 365 days, with an extra day added every fourth year (0.25 days for each year). The Julian calendar became widely used throughout the Roman Empire, which stretched across Europe and into north Africa, and parts of Asia.



This Aztec Sun stone served an unknown purpose, but shows the symbols for the months as well as other periods of time in the Mesoamerican calendar.